

PREMIUM RESOURCE · AI & FINANCE AUTOMATION

Finance Bot Build Guide

Power Automate + Copilot

A step-by-step guide to building finance-specific bots using Power Automate and Copilot — 5 practical use cases with full build instructions, testing, governance, and maintenance guidance.

5 Finance Bot Use Cases

Full Build Instructions

Testing & Governance

Premium · €49

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BEFORE YOU START

Microsoft has iterated on Copilot in Power Automate multiple times within a single year, and several capabilities referenced here — particularly natural-language flow generation — remain in active preview. Treat the build steps as directionally accurate rather than an exact click-by-click script, and confirm current menu names and licensing directly in your own tenant. You'll also need a Power Automate Premium licence (or Microsoft 365 Copilot licence) and AI Builder credits for the invoice-processing bot specifically.

SECTION 1

How Copilot Builds Flows for You

What Copilot in Power Automate actually does, how to prompt it well, and where human review still has to happen.

Copilot in Power Automate is a conversational interface built into the flow designer. Instead of manually selecting a trigger, adding actions one at a time, and configuring each connector, you describe what you want in natural language, across multiple turns of conversation if needed, and Copilot proposes a working flow — setting up connections, applying parameters, and letting you request changes in plain language afterward.

Writing a Prompt That Actually Works

A vague prompt like “automate approvals” leaves Copilot to guess at the connector, the condition, and the outcome — and it will guess. A good prompt names all four of these explicitly:

- ☐ The **trigger** — what event starts the flow.

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- ☐ The **app or system** involved — SharePoint, Outlook, Teams, Dynamics 365, and so on.
 - ☐ The **condition**, if any — what should branch the flow's behaviour.
 - ☐ The **outcome** — what should happen at the end, and for whom.
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EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"When a new SharePoint list item is created, send an approval to the manager and email the requester after approval."

Editing a Flow With Copilot

Once a flow exists, prefer narrow, specific edit requests over broad regeneration — a targeted instruction is far less likely to disturb a trigger or condition that's already working correctly.

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"Add a condition that continues only when Status equals Approved."

AN ACCELERATOR, NOT A REPLACEMENT FOR REVIEW

Every Copilot-generated flow still needs a human to check the trigger frequency, the connector permissions, who receives notifications, and what happens on failure, before it runs unattended for a team. Treat each Copilot output as a strong first draft — not a finished, review-free deliverable.

SECTION 2

The 5 Finance Bot Use Cases

Full build instructions for five practical finance bots, each with a working Copilot prompt, step-by-step build sequence, and the connectors involved.

01 Invoice Intake & AP Approval Bot

Extracts invoice data automatically and routes for approval based on amount.

TRIGGER

A new invoice file is added to a SharePoint document library (or received as an email attachment).

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"When a new invoice arrives in my SharePoint library, extract the vendor name, invoice number, and total amount using AI Builder, and if the amount exceeds \$10,000 send it to my manager for approval in Teams, otherwise notify the AP team it's ready to post."

BUILD STEPS

- 1 Add the trigger**
"When a file is created" (SharePoint) pointed at your invoices library, or "When a new email arrives" (Outlook) filtered to invoices with an attachment.
- 2 Add the AI Builder document processing action**
Use a pre-built or custom-trained invoice processing model to extract vendor name, invoice number, amount, and due date from the attached file.
- 3 Add a condition on the extracted amount**
Branch the flow: amounts above your threshold route to approval; amounts below post automatically.
- 4 Add the approval action for the high branch**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to the relevant approver, with the extracted fields shown in the approval card.
- 5 Add the posting or notification action for the low branch**
Post directly to your accounting system's inbox process, or notify the AP team the item is ready.
- 6 Add a rejection path**
If the approval is rejected, notify the submitter and log the rejection reason rather than letting the flow simply end.

CONNECTORS USED

SharePoint or Outlook (trigger), AI Builder (document processing), Office 365 Users (approver lookup), Approvals connector, Teams or Outlook (notifications).

NOTES

AI Builder's document processing models work on a model-per-layout basis — a model trained on one vendor's invoice format may not generalise well to a very differently formatted invoice from another vendor. Expect to train or fine-tune the model against a representative sample of your actual invoice layouts before relying on it.

02 Expense Report Approval Routing Bot

Routes expense submissions to the right approver, with extra sign-off above a threshold.

TRIGGER

A new item is added to an expense report SharePoint list, form, or Dynamics 365 entity.

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"When a new item is added to my Expense Reports SharePoint list, get the submitter's manager and send them an approval request. If the amount is over \$2,000, also require finance director approval after the manager approves."

BUILD STEPS

- 1 Add the trigger**
"When an item is created" on your expense reports list or form response table.
- 2 Look up the submitter's manager**
"Get manager (V2)" (Office 365 Users connector), using the submitter's email as input — this avoids hardcoding a manager's email that will go stale when reporting lines change.
- 3 Add the first approval**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to the manager's email from the previous step, not a static address.
- 4 Add a condition on the amount**
If the amount exceeds your secondary threshold, continue to a second approval; otherwise proceed to completion.
- 5 Add the second approval**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to the finance director, triggered only after the manager approval succeeds.
- 6 Update the record and notify the submitter**
Write the final status back to the source list and email the submitter the outcome either way.

CONNECTORS USED

SharePoint or Dataverse (trigger), Office 365 Users ("Get manager (V2)"), Approvals connector, Outlook (notifications).

NOTES

Always resolve the manager dynamically rather than hardcoding an email address in the flow — a hardcoded approver is the single most common reason these flows silently break when someone changes teams or leaves the organisation.

03

Vendor Onboarding & Contract Approval Bot

Runs a new vendor contract through sequential Legal, Finance, and executive sign-off.

TRIGGER

A new contract document is uploaded to a Vendor Contracts SharePoint library.

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"When a new contract is uploaded to the Vendor Contracts library, start a sequential approval with Legal, then Finance, then the CFO, and email the vendor manager once all three approve."

BUILD STEPS

- 1 Add the trigger**
"When a file is created" on the Vendor Contracts library, filtered to a specific folder or content type if the library holds other document types too.
- 2 Add the first approval stage**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to the Legal reviewer, with a link back to the document.
- 3 Add a condition on the outcome**
If rejected, notify the vendor manager and stop the flow rather than silently continuing to the next stage.
- 4 Add the second approval stage**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to Finance, triggered only after Legal approves.
- 5 Add the third approval stage**
"Start and wait for an approval" assigned to the CFO, triggered only after Finance approves.
- 6 Update metadata and notify on completion**
Update the document's SharePoint status column to "Approved" and email the vendor manager once all three stages succeed.

CONNECTORS USED

SharePoint (trigger and metadata update), Approvals connector, Outlook or Teams (notifications).

NOTES

Sequential approvals should each have their own rejection path. A common design mistake is building one rejection branch for the whole flow, which loses the information about which specific stage rejected the contract and why.

04

Month-End Close Checklist & Reminder Bot

Posts the recurring close checklist automatically and escalates overdue tasks.

TRIGGER

A scheduled recurrence, timed a few business days before month-end.

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"Every month on the 25th, post a message in my Finance Close Teams channel listing this month's close tasks, and send a reminder to anyone who hasn't marked their task complete by the 28th."

BUILD STEPS

- 1 Add a recurrence trigger**
Set it to run monthly on a fixed day (e.g. the 25th), rather than a fixed date that won't adjust for weekends or short months.
- 2 Post the checklist to Teams**
Post an adaptive card or message in the Finance Close channel listing each close task and its owner, pulled from a Planner plan or SharePoint list.
- 3 Add a second, later recurrence for the reminder check**
A day or two before close is due, query the same Planner plan or list for incomplete tasks.
- 4 Add a condition per task or a loop**
For each incomplete task, send a direct reminder to its owner rather than a single generic channel message that's easy to ignore.
- 5 Escalate persistent non-completion**
If a task is still incomplete after the reminder, notify the close owner or controller directly rather than repeating the same reminder indefinitely.

CONNECTORS USED

Recurrence trigger, Planner or SharePoint (task source), Teams (posting and reminders).

NOTES

This bot is lower risk than the others since it doesn't touch financial data directly — a good first build for a team new to Power Automate, and a useful way to build confidence before tackling the approval-routing bots.

05

PO-to-Invoice Matching Exception Alert Bot

Flags invoices that don't match their purchase order within an acceptable tolerance.

TRIGGER

An invoice has just been processed (this can extend the Invoice Intake bot above, or trigger independently once invoice data lands in a table).

EXAMPLE COPILOT PROMPT

"When an invoice is extracted, look up the matching purchase order by PO number, and if the invoice amount is more than 2% different from the PO amount, send an exception alert to the AP analyst in Teams."

BUILD STEPS

- 1 Add the trigger**
Either extend the Invoice Intake bot's flow after the AI Builder extraction step, or trigger from a new row landing in your invoice staging table.
- 2 Look up the matching purchase order**
Query your ERP, Dataverse, or SQL connector for the PO record matching the invoice's PO number field.
- 3 Calculate the variance**
Compute the percentage difference between the invoice amount and the PO amount using an expression.
- 4 Add a condition on the tolerance threshold**
If the variance exceeds your tolerance (e.g. 2%), branch to the exception path; otherwise continue to normal processing.
- 5 Send the exception alert**
Notify the AP analyst in Teams with the invoice number, PO number, and both amounts so they don't have to look anything up to start investigating.
- 6 Log every exception, not just the alert**
Write each flagged exception to a tracking list — this becomes your audit trail for "why was this invoice held," not just a fire-and-forget notification.

CONNECTORS USED

SQL Server, Dataverse, or Dynamics 365 (PO lookup), Teams (alerts), SharePoint or Dataverse (exception log).

NOTES

Power Automate's own run history shows that a flow executed — it does not, on its own, give you a durable, queryable record of why a specific invoice was flagged. Logging exceptions to a separate table is what actually gives you an audit trail a reviewer or auditor can query later.

SECTION 3

Testing & Governance Protocol

How to test a finance bot properly before it runs unattended, and the governance controls that keep a growing library of flows under control.

Testing Before Go-Live

- 1 **Test with realistic, non-production data first**
Use a copy of real invoice formats, expense amounts, and approval chains — synthetic “test test test” data won't surface the edge cases that actually break a flow.
- 2 **Deliberately test the rejection and failure paths**
Approve one test case and reject another; confirm both produce the correct downstream behaviour, not just the happy path.
- 3 **Check what happens when a lookup finds nothing**
A missing manager, a missing PO record, or a failed AI Builder extraction should produce a clear failure notification, not a flow that fails silently.
- 4 **Review trigger frequency before enabling**
Confirm the flow won't fire more often than intended — a trigger on “any file change” instead of “file created” can multiply runs unexpectedly.
- 5 **Confirm connector permissions match the intended scope**
Check the flow's connections aren't running under a personal account with broader access than the process actually needs.

Governance Checklist

Work through this before a finance bot touches real financial data for a whole team, not just for your own testing.

- ☐ A Data Loss Prevention (DLP) policy is in place classifying connectors into Business, Non-Business, and Blocked groups — so a finance flow can't be built that quietly connects an internal data source to a consumer service.
- ☐ Flows that touch financial data are built and tested in a non-production environment before promotion to Production.
- ☐ Every flow has a named, current owner — not the person who happened to build it three years ago and has since left.
- ☐ Makers complete basic governance training before being permitted to create flows in the Production environment.
- ☐ New or materially changed flows go through an IT or Center of Excellence review before deployment, not just before initial launch.
- ☐ A quarterly audit reviews flow owners, active connections, and DLP policy violations, and deactivates flows with no current owner or stale connections.

A genuine limitation to plan around: Power Automate's run history confirms that a flow executed, but it does not by itself give you a durable, transaction-level record of exactly why a specific decision was made — useful for a regulated finance process. Where an auditable decision trail matters (as in the PO-matching bot above), log the decision and its inputs to a separate table deliberately, rather than relying on run history alone.

SECTION 4

Maintenance & Update Guide

What actually needs ongoing attention once these bots are live, so they keep working rather than quietly degrading.

- 1 Monitor AI Builder credit consumption**
Invoice and document processing actions consume credits per run — a sudden volume spike can exhaust monthly capacity faster than expected.
- 2 Retrain or extend AI Builder models as formats change**
A new vendor with an unfamiliar invoice layout, or a redesigned expense form, can quietly reduce extraction accuracy until the model is retrained.
- 3 Review run history for recurring failures**
A flow that fails the same way repeatedly is telling you something about a changed system, not just having a bad day.
- 4 Reassign flow ownership proactively**
When a flow owner changes role or leaves, transfer ownership deliberately — an orphaned flow with no owner is a governance gap waiting to be found in an audit.
- 5 Revisit approval thresholds periodically**
Amount thresholds set a year ago may no longer reflect current budget sizes or risk tolerance — review them at least annually.

WHERE TO START

If your organisation is new to Power Automate, build the Month-End Close Checklist bot first — it doesn't touch financial transactions directly, so it's the lowest-risk way to build real confidence with triggers, conditions, and Copilot's prompt style before moving on to the approval-routing and invoice-matching bots.

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FINANCE AUTOMATION BUILD SUPPORT

For hands-on support building or troubleshooting these bots in your own tenant — including DLP policy design and Center of Excellence setup — a bespoke engagement is available on request.

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